

ICC RANKING: **6th**

BEST WC PERFORMANCE QUARTERFINAL (1997)

STRENGTHS

Sri Lanka's batting has gained depth beyond Chamari Athapaththu. From June 2022 to August 2024, the top three – Athapaththu, Harshitha Samarawickrama, and Vishmi Gunaratne – accounted for 47 per cent of the team's runs across 23 matches. Samarawickrama has been particularly consistent, averaging 48 this year, while the middle order of Nilakshika Silva and Kavisha Dilhari has provided stability. Hasini Perera's shift to opener has also steadied the top.

WEAKNESSES

Despite progress, Athapaththu's dominance remains stark: her 1,088 runs in the 2022–25 Championship cycle more than doubled Samarawickrama's tally. If Athapaththu falters, the batting can still buckle under pressure. In addition, several key players, including Gunaratne and Dilhari, are relatively inexperienced at major global events, a vulnerability that stronger teams can exploit.

OPPORTUNITIES

This squad has demonstrated its ability to upset higher-ranked sides, with nine wins in the cycle, including a record chase against South Africa and a landmark series win over New Zealand. Dilhari's rise as an all-rounder, finishing as the leading wicket-taker (25 wickets at 26.24), adds balance. This year, young bowlers Dewmi Vihangi (11 wickets) and Malki Madara (6) offer fresh unpredictability to complement veteran Sugandika Kumari (9).

THREATS

After missing the 2022 edition, Sri Lanka faces both rust and scrutiny. A seven-month layoff before its ODI return (2-0 series loss) against New Zealand this year exposed fragility, while the attack still lacks sustained penetration against elite batting line-ups. The combination of inexperience and a bowling unit that can fade under pressure leaves the side vulnerable to collapses.

PREDICTION

Sri Lanka enters as a dangerous underdog. The team is better equipped to spring upsets than to mount a sustained run. If support around Athapaththu holds and the bowling unit continues to evolve, it could derail bigger campaigns. But a deep push will hinge on how well it reduces overreliance on its veteran.

Rajdeep Saha

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CAPTAIN
CHAMARI ATHAPATHTHU

COACH
RUMESH RATNAYAKE